

CHAPTER III

THE CYRUS-BABYLON INTERPOLATIONS

It has been shown in the preceding chapters that the attempt to explain Second Isaiah as a prophecy addressed to the deported Jews in Babylonia breaks down completely and ends in chaos. The occurrence of the names "Cyrus, Babylon, Chaldea" in passages of obviously central significance claims for the poems a very definite situation and intention. In each instance, however, the claim is belied by the immediate context (a startling fact), while the effort to maintain it throughout even one of the chapters concerned is found fruitless, necessitating excisions and emendations of a well-attested text. There is hardly a single poem in the postulated literary unit 40-55 which can be forced into the required historical situation, and even after the scissors have been courageously applied our commentators must "lament the inconsistencies" of the prophet. He persistently loses sight of the thing he is supposed to be saying; while employing the same phrases which had seemed to mark him as 'the Prophet of the Exile' he deals with ideas quite incongruous with the situation in Babylonia and the year 540; in every single instance where he has seemed to be indulging in extravagant utterances regarding the Persian king there is more than a suspicion that he has in mind a greater and more enduring factor in the history of mankind. It is clear that he believes himself to be uttering things of great importance, not for Israel only but for all the world; our commentators easily show this to be a delusion.

There is something wrong here, and it will presently be seen that the trouble is not deep-seated, but purely an external matter. By a few slight touches here and there in well-chosen places it is possible to disguise any human face. By a similar process new and misleading features have been added to many ancient documents, since the time when interpreters first began to demand (and achieve) certainty in place of ambiguity, and propagandists to seek documentary authority for their views.

We have here before us what is doubtless the most important example of such disguise in all the history of literature. With the half-dozen slight but potent touches removed, we see one of the